

# Assumption Validation & Product Evolution Log

A self-verification review of the deployed FocusBuddy MVP — documenting where initial product assumptions were challenged by real usage, and how the product evolved as a result.

|               |                                                                                             |
|---------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
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| Product       | FocusBuddy — AI Co-Pilot for Task Paralysis & Executive Dysfunction                         |
| Document type | Post-deployment self-verification / assumption audit                                        |
| Source repo   | <a href="https://github.com/VarshaJha-14/FocusBuddy">github.com/VarshaJha-14/FocusBuddy</a> |

*“This document doesn’t just show the product — it shows how the product changed when its own assumptions were challenged.”*

## 1. Purpose of This Document

Most PM portfolios present a finished product and stop there. This document takes the opposite approach: it is a record of self-verification performed on the deployed FocusBuddy MVP, capturing every place where a founding assumption did not survive contact with real (or simulated) user behavior — and the concrete product decision that followed.

The goal is not to prove the original plan was right. It is to show the reasoning trail: assumption → validation → evolution. That trail is what separates a static feature list from a product that is actually being managed.

## 2. Assumption-by-Assumption Findings

| ASSUMPTION 1       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|--------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Initial Assumption | People cannot start tasks because they don't know where to begin. The MVP solution, in response, was to break tasks into micro-steps.                                                                                                                                                                               |
| Validation Insight | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Not always true. Many neurodivergent users already know exactly what they need to do — the plan is not the missing piece.</li><li>• Their real barrier is emotional: resistance, overwhelm, perfectionism, demand avoidance, or anxiety — not a lack of planning.</li></ul> |
| Product Decision   | FocusBuddy should reposition from a <b>Task Breakdown AI</b> to an <b>Adaptive Support AI</b> .                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |

| ASSUMPTION 2       |                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Initial Assumption | Micro-steps work for everyone as the universal entry point into a task.                                                                                                                    |
| Validation Insight | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Some users feel patronized, controlled, or overwhelmed by being handed instructions, and become resistant to being told what to do next.</li></ul> |
| Product Decision   | Allow multiple support modes so the product adapts to the user rather than the reverse.<br>Examples: Gentle Companion, Coach, Listener, Organizer, Silent Accountability.                  |

## ASSUMPTION 3

## Initial Assumption

The AI should proactively guide users through every interaction.

## Validation Insight

- Some users want less interaction, not more — proactive guidance can itself become a source of friction.

## Product Decision

Introduce an **Adaptive Intervention Engine** that first identifies what type of support the user currently wants, before deciding how (or whether) to intervene.

## ASSUMPTION 4

## Initial Assumption

Productivity is equivalent to task completion.

## Validation Insight

- Sometimes starting is already success — completion is not always the meaningful unit of progress for this user base.

## Product Decision

Change the North Star Metric.  
Old: Task Completion Rate → New: Task Initiation Confidence / Task Activation Velocity.

## ASSUMPTION 5

## Initial Assumption

One conversational style fits everyone.

## Validation Insight

- Tone sensitivity varies widely: some users need encouragement, others want neutrality, others want humour, and others want silence.

## Product Decision

Build a **Dynamic Personality Engine** that adjusts conversational tone per user rather than shipping a single fixed voice.

## ASSUMPTION 6

## Initial Assumption

Daily check-ins improve engagement.

## Validation Insight

- For some users, notifications become guilt triggers rather than motivators, actively working against the product's purpose.

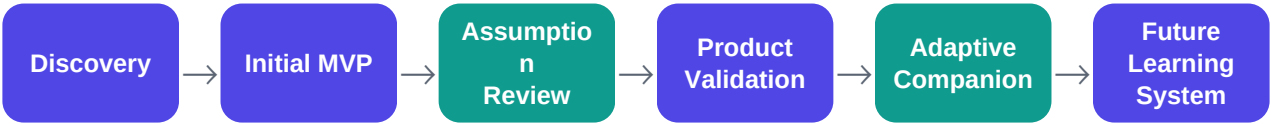
## Product Decision

Introduce **Adaptive Reminder Frequency** instead of a fixed daily check-in cadence.

| ASSUMPTION 7       |                                                                                                                                               |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Initial Assumption | Users always want to solve the task in front of them.                                                                                         |
| Validation Insight | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Sometimes users don't need productivity help at all — they need emotional regulation first.</li></ul> |
| Product Decision   | Introduce an <b>Emotional Reset Mode</b> as an alternative path to tasks, not a replacement for them.                                         |

| ASSUMPTION 8       |                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|--------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Initial Assumption | Executive dysfunction is a single, uniform problem.                                                                                                                                               |
| Validation Insight | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Different underlying causes — ADHD, autism, burnout, depression, anxiety, sleep deprivation — can produce very similar surface-level behaviour.</li></ul> |
| Product Decision   | Optimize for <b>task initiation barriers</b> , not diagnoses — a shift that broadens the product's reach while staying true to its original purpose.                                              |

### 3. Product Evolution Timeline



### 4. New Vision

**OLD VISION**

An AI that helps users start tasks.



**NEW VISION**

An adaptive AI companion that identifies the specific barrier preventing action and responds with the most supportive intervention for that moment.

*This is a materially stronger vision than the one FocusBuddy launched with — it keeps the same emotional core (getting people unstuck) while removing the assumption that one mechanism (micro-steps) is the universal answer.*

## 5. Why This Document Is Valuable

Most PM portfolios show:

*“Here’s the product.”*

Very few show:

*“Here’s how the product changed when we challenged our own assumptions.”*

That distinction demonstrates intellectual honesty and product maturity — it shows the ability to hold a hypothesis loosely, test it against reality, and change course in public rather than defending the original plan.

## 6. Assumptions We Got Wrong

| Initial Assumption                   | What We Learned                                   | Product Evolution                               |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Users don’t know where to start      | Many know exactly what to do                      | Focus on emotional friction instead of planning |
| Micro-steps help everyone            | Some users reject being told what to do           | Multiple support modes                          |
| One AI personality is sufficient     | Support preferences vary daily                    | Adaptive Companion Engine                       |
| Productivity equals completing tasks | Starting is often the hardest win                 | New success metric: Task Initiation Confidence  |
| More reminders increase engagement   | Excess reminders can create guilt                 | Adaptive reminder frequency                     |
| Diagnosis-specific design is best    | Different conditions can produce similar barriers | Design around barriers, not diagnoses           |

*Note: FocusBuddy is a PM case-study concept product (not a live clinical or commercial application). This log reflects a self-directed verification pass on the deployed demo, used to pressure-test the original product assumptions ahead of the next design iteration.*